the past were never repeated. Interim Conservative leader of the Opposition Rona Ambrose and NDP leader Tom Mulcair endorsed Trudeau's apology and also apologized on their respective parties' behalf. [10]

Establishing a network

During my posting at Ottawa, India's consular and visa services in Canada were handled by two Indian consulates (Vancouver and Toronto) and the Indian High Commission at Ottawa. The two western provinces of Alberta and British Columbia were served from Vancouver, and the provinces of Manitoba, Saskatchewan and Ontario from Toronto. The city of Ottawa, which was otherwise part of the Ontario province, and the four eastern provinces of Quebec, New Brunswick, Nova Scotia, and Newfoundland and Labrador, were served directly from Ottawa. Besides being in charge of these services at the high commission, I also coordinated consular work of the two consulates on behalf of the high commissioner.

As first secretary in charge of consular and visa services at the mission, I started contacting (on the phone and through personal meetings wherever feasible) my relatives, friends and contacts spread over various parts of Canada and the west coast of the US. Soon I was able to build a fairly large 'information bank' about the kinds of problems that persons of Indian origin, especially those from Punjab (mainly Sikhs), were facing in Canada and in the west coast of the US. I also noted the external influences on the community.

In July 1978 my in-laws came to visit us for a month and a half. I took one month's leave and drove them and my family across the prairies from Ottawa to Vancouver via Edmonton. Then we travelled southwards, from Vancouver to Yuba City, San Francisco, Stockton, Sacramento, Los Angeles and San Diego, and back to Ottawa via Las Vegas, the Grand Canyon, Yellowstone Park, Calgary, and so on. At many of these places (other than those of tourist interest) we met several people of Punjabi origin. At the Yuba City and Stockton gurudwaras, several Sikhs turned up to meet my father-in-law Sardar Swaran Singh. A few of them who